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Just before the interview with *Business Today*, Christian Sobottka had completed an eight-kilometre run, a ritual he keeps at least three times a week. Sports is his second passion. The first is staying connected to family and friends. “That kind of outside perspective is a source of real reflection and energy,” says Sobottka, who took over as CEO & President, Automotive Division at HARMAN in March 2025, guiding the wholly-owned subsidiary of Samsung Electronics towards a more product- and software-centric model. HARMAN International designs and engineers connected products and solutions for automakers, consumers, and enterprises worldwide.

Before joining the \$11-billion company in 2021, Sobottka held senior leadership roles at Robert Bosch Automotive Steering GmbH, serving as CEO, CTO, and chairman of the executive board. His career spans engineering, sales, marketing, and operations—a breadth that gives him a holistic view of the industry’s transformation. India is key to that transformation, where 5,000 of the 30,000 employees are based.

Sobottka studied Electrical Engineering at Technische Universität Darmstadt in Germany and holds an Executive MBA from the University of

Bradford, UK. He discusses shifts in the industry, impact of global geopolitical developments, tariffs, India strategy, and more. Edited excerpts:

Q: You took over as CEO in the middle of some of the biggest shifts in automotive—software-defined vehicles, AI integration, changing consumer expectations. How are you redefining the company’s role?

A: The industry has been evolving for a while. What’s fundamentally changing is the role of the car itself. It’s shifting from a device that organises transport into something that connects you to your digital life and the world around you.

Our vision is centred on the organised ‘consumer

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experience in the car’ but delivered at ‘automotive grade’ and at the speed of the tech industry.

The first challenge is compressing the development cadence from three or four years to one. The second is creating valuable user experiences—now AI-orchestrated and context-aware—that become the real differentiator for what people feel inside the car.

Q: In your first year as the CEO, you made three key decisions—the €1.5-billion acquisition of ZF’s Advanced Driver Assistance Systems business, acquisition of Sound United and divestment of Digital Transformation Solutions to Wipro. What was the strategic logic?

A: The logic is straightforward: we acquire where we can build or reinforce a leading position, and we divest where others can do it better than us.